490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 5 OF 26

Ruin Spreads: Cain, the Flood, and Babel

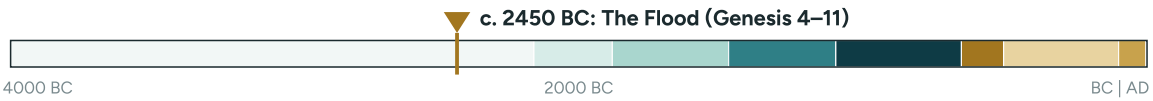
Genesis 4–11



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 5



Introduction: Sin Grows Up Fast

A crack in a windshield starts as a chip the size of a fingernail. You tell yourself you will get it fixed. Then a cold morning comes, and the defroster runs, and by the time you get to work the crack runs from one side of the glass to the other. Small breaks do not stay small.

Last week we watched the first sin: one bite of forbidden fruit in a garden. Genesis 4 through 11 shows what that chip does to the whole windshield. In one chapter, a brother kills a brother. A few generations later, a man boasts of killing for a bruise. By chapter 6 the earth is "filled with violence" (Gen. 6:11), and God sends a flood. Even after the flood, humanity gathers on a plain to build a tower to heaven and make a name for itself. These chapters cover more time than any other stretch of the Bible, perhaps two thousand years, and they move quickly, because they are showing you one thing: what sin does when it is left to grow.

But watch for the other thing these chapters show. Every time sin breaks out, judgment comes, and every time judgment comes, God holds out grace. The ruin spreads. So does the mercy. And the line of the promised Offspring from Genesis 3:15 keeps going, name by name, through the darkness.

The Word: Favor

> **Genesis 6:5–8** *"The LORD saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually. And the LORD regretted that he had made man on the earth, and it grieved him to his heart. So the LORD said, 'I will blot out man whom I have created from the face of the land, man and animals and creeping things and birds of the heavens, for I am sorry that I have made them.' But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."*

חֵן *(ḥen, "favor, grace")*

favor; acceptance freely given. When God gives it, undeserved

חָנַן (ḥanan)

"to be gracious"

The verb behind it. When God names himself to Moses, he is "merciful and *gracious*" (Ex. 34:6), from the same root.

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חֵן (ḥen)

"favor, grace"

Genesis 6:8 is the first time the word appears in the Bible. Its first use is a man finding grace in a world under judgment.

Payoff: Look at the order of Genesis 6:8–9. First, "Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." Only then, in the next verse, "Noah was a righteous man, blameless in his generation. Noah walked with God." Grace comes first, and the godly life follows it. Noah was not saved because he was the one good man in a bad world. Hebrews says he "became an heir of the righteousness that comes by faith" (Heb. 11:7). There is even a small wordplay in the Hebrew: the two letters of Noah's name (נֹחַ) reversed spell the word for grace (חֵן). The first time the Bible uses its great word for grace, it is a mirror of a sinner's name.

Part One: Cain and Abel



"And the LORD had regard for Abel and his offering, but for Cain and his offering he had no regard" (Gen. 4:4–5).

Outside the garden, Adam and Eve have children. When Cain is born, Eve says, "I have gotten a man with the help of the LORD" (Gen. 4:1). Maybe she hoped he was the promised Offspring. He was not. Two brothers grow up: Abel keeps sheep, Cain works the ground. Both bring an offering to God. Abel brings "the firstborn of his flock and of their fat portions," and God accepts it. Cain brings "an offering of the fruit of the ground," and God does not (4:3–5).

Why the difference? Genesis hints at it: Abel brought the best of what he had, the firstborn and the fat portions, while Cain simply brought some fruit. But the New Testament gives the deeper reason: "By faith Abel offered to God a more acceptable sacrifice than Cain" (Heb. 11:4). The difference was in their hearts. Abel came trusting God. Cain came going through the motions, and when God did not accept him, he was furious. John says Cain "was of the evil one and murdered his brother… because his own deeds were evil and his brother's righteous" (1 John 3:12).

Before Cain acted, God spoke to him with remarkable patience: "Why are you angry, and why has your face fallen? If you do well, will you not be accepted? And if you do not do well, sin is crouching at the door. Its desire is for you, and you must rule over it" (4:6–7). This is the first time the word "sin" appears in the Bible, and God describes it as an animal crouched at the door, waiting to pounce. Every one of us has stood at that door with Cain.

Cain did not rule over it. He led his brother into a field and killed him. And God came with a question again, as he did in the garden: "Where is Abel your brother?" Cain answered with a lie and a sneer: "I do not know; am I my brother's keeper?" (4:9). Then God said, "The voice of your brother's blood is crying to me from the ground" (4:10). Abel's blood cried out for justice. Hold on to that sentence. The New Testament will answer it.

Even here, God showed mercy. He drove Cain away, but when Cain feared that someone would kill him, God put a mark on him to protect him (4:15). The murderer was shown mercy he never showed his brother.

Part Two: Two Lines

From here, Genesis follows two family lines. Cain's line builds a city and gives the world herding, music, and metalwork (4:17–22). Human culture is real and good, and it comes from people made in God's image even when they do not honor him. But the father of those inventors, a man named Lamech, five generations after Cain (not the Lamech of Genesis 5, who was Noah's father), sings this to his wives:

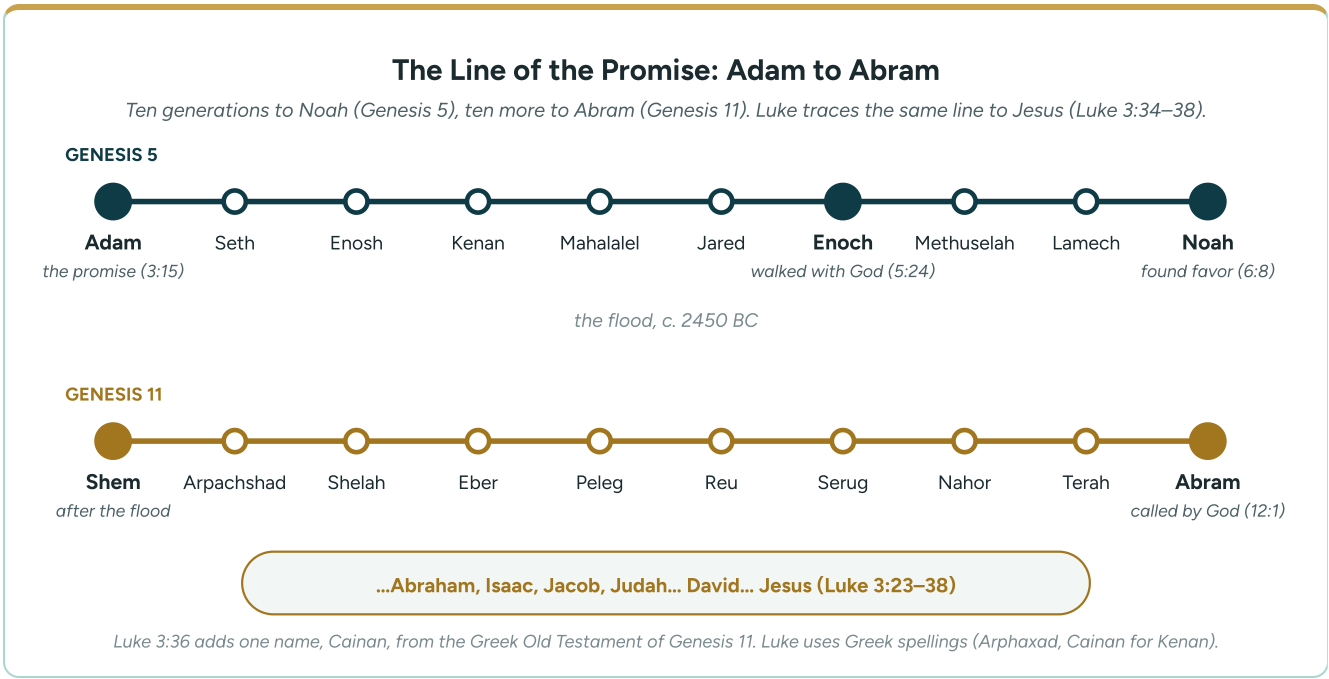
> **Genesis 4:23–24** *"Lamech said to his wives: 'Adah and Zillah, hear my voice; you wives of Lamech, listen to what I say: I have killed a man for wounding me, a young man for striking me. If Cain's revenge is sevenfold, then Lamech's is seventy-sevenfold.'"*

Lamech took God's promise to protect Cain, "vengeance shall be taken on him sevenfold" (4:15), and turned it into a boast. Hurt me once, and I will destroy you seventy-seven times over. In *Seventy Times Seven* I called this the score-keeping heart, fully grown, glaring out at us from the dawn of the world. And then, thousands of years later, Peter asked Jesus how many times he had to forgive his brother. Seven? Jesus answered, "I do not say to you seven times, but seventy-seven times" (Matt. 18:22). (The ESV's footnote gives the other way to read it, "seventy times seven," which is where 490 Life gets its name.) In the Greek Old Testament, the translation many Jews of Jesus' day read, Lamech's boast uses the very same phrase Jesus used. Jesus reached back to the oldest, darkest math in the Bible and flipped the sign. Where Lamech multiplied vengeance, Jesus multiplies mercy.

The other line runs through Seth, the son God gave Adam and Eve "instead of Abel" (4:25). And at the end of chapter 4, a small sentence glows in the dark: "At that time people began to call upon the name of the LORD" (4:26). While Cain's line built a city, Seth's line prayed.

Genesis 5 traces Seth's line from Adam to Noah, ten generations, and it reads like a cemetery. Over and over, the same refrain: "and he died." The curse of Genesis 3 is working its way down the family tree. But one man breaks the pattern: "Enoch walked with God, and he was not, for God took him" (5:24). In a chapter of funerals, one man did not die. It was a small sign that death would not have the last word.

You will also notice the ages. Adam lived 930 years (5:5), Methuselah 969 (5:27). Genesis gives these as real lifespans, and they are the numbers behind the timeline in Lesson 1. After the flood they fall fast. Shem lived 600 years, Abraham 175, and by Moses' day seventy or eighty was a full life (Ps. 90:10). Shrinking lifespans are the curse of Genesis 3 doing its work.



Part Three: The Flood

Genesis 6 opens with one of the strangest passages in the Bible: "the sons of God saw that the daughters of man were attractive. And they took as their wives any they chose" (6:2). It also mentions the Nephilim (6:4). Faithful Christians read this in more than one way. Augustine and Calvin took "the sons of God" as the godly line of Seth marrying into Cain's line, so that the people who called on the LORD were swallowed up by the world. Others take them as fallen angels (compare Jude 6), or as powerful rulers. You do not need to settle it this week. On any of these readings, the line between those who called on God and those who did not was disappearing.

By Genesis 6, the ruin has spread everywhere: "The LORD saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually" (6:5). Read that slowly: every intention, continually. The earth was "filled with violence" (6:11). And Genesis says, "it grieved him to his heart" (6:6). The judgment that follows is the judgment of a holy God who takes evil with complete seriousness.

Does that mean God made a mistake, or changed his mind? Lesson 2 taught us that God does not change (Mal. 3:6), and Scripture says it outright: "he is not a man, that he should have regret" (1 Sam. 15:29). When Genesis says the LORD "regretted" and was "grieved," it uses human language so we can grasp something true about him, the same way this passage speaks of "the eyes of the LORD." The Westminster Confession says God is "without body, parts, or passions" (WCF 2.1). He is never knocked off balance by moods the way we are. The words still tell us something real. God is not indifferent to evil. His holy love, which never changes, stands against what humanity had become. The flood came from the same unchanging God who had said that sin leads to death (Gen. 2:17), now meeting a world that had changed for the worse.

"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD" (6:8). God told Noah to build an ark, a huge wooden box covered with pitch, and to bring his family and the animals into it. Noah obeyed. Peter calls him "a herald of righteousness" (2 Pet. 2:5), and the years of building were a warning to everyone watching, while "God's patience waited in the days of Noah, while the ark was being prepared" (1 Pet. 3:20). Then "all the fountains of the great deep burst forth, and the windows of the heavens were opened" (7:11), and the rain fell for forty days and forty nights. One small detail is easy to miss: when everyone was inside, "the LORD shut him in" (7:16). Noah did not close the door; God closed it behind him.

Genesis says the waters covered "all the high mountains under the whole heaven" (7:19). The plain reading, and the one this study follows, is that the flood covered the whole earth. Some Christians who hold firmly to the Bible's authority read "the whole earth" the way Genesis sometimes uses it, as the whole world of the people involved (compare 41:57), and take the flood as vast but regional. On either reading, the flood was a real judgment in real history, around 2450 BC on the timeline this study follows, and everyone outside the ark perished (7:23). Jesus spoke of it as history: "as in those days before the flood they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, until the day when Noah entered the ark, and they were unaware until the flood came and swept them all away, so will be the coming of the Son of Man" (Matt. 24:38–39). The flood is a preview of the final judgment.



"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth" (Gen. 9:13).

Then come four of the most hopeful words in Genesis: "But God remembered Noah" (8:1). To "remember" in the Bible means to act on a commitment. Before the rain ever fell, God had told Noah, "I will establish my covenant with you" (6:18), the first time the word "covenant" appears in the Bible. Now he acted on it. The waters went down, and Noah and his family stepped out onto a washed earth. The first thing Noah did was build an altar and offer sacrifices, and "the LORD smelled the pleasing aroma" (8:21).

Then God confirmed that covenant, a binding promise, with Noah and "every living creature" (9:10): "never again shall all flesh be cut off by the waters of the flood" (9:11). The sign was the rainbow. "While the earth remains, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease" (8:22). Reformed teachers have often called this a covenant of preservation. God promised to keep the world going, sun and rain and harvest for the just and the unjust (theologians call this common grace), so that his plan of rescue would have a world to unfold in. Every time you see a rainbow, you are looking at God's promise to hold the world together until Jesus, the promised Offspring who has already come, comes again.

But notice why God made that promise. "I will never again curse the ground because of man, for the intention of man's heart is evil from his youth" (8:21). The flood washed the earth, but it did not wash the human heart. Almost the next thing we read about Noah is that he got drunk and lay uncovered in his tent (9:20–21). The man who found grace was still a sinner who needed it. Something deeper was needed.

Part Four: Babel



"Come, let us build ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves" (Gen. 11:4).

After the flood, as people migrated, they found a plain in the land of Shinar, later called Babylonia, and settled there (11:2). They had one language, and they had a plan: "Come, let us build ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves, lest we be dispersed over the face of the whole earth" (11:4). Two things drove them. They wanted to make a name for themselves, and they refused to spread out and fill the earth as God had commanded (9:1). Babel was humanity building together for its own glory, against God's word.

Then comes a line with a touch of holy humor: "And the LORD came down to see the city and the tower" (11:5). They built a tower "with its top in the heavens," and God had to come down to see it. So God confused their language and scattered them over the earth. Even that was mercy. God said that if they went on as one, "nothing that they propose to do will now be impossible for them" (11:6). Scattering put a limit on what united human pride could do. The name Babel sounds like the Hebrew for "confused" (11:9).

Then the story turns. Genesis 11 closes with the family line from Shem down to a man named Abram, and one sad detail: "Sarai was barren; she had no child" (11:10–32). The very next chapter begins with God speaking to him: "And I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you and make your name great… and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed" (12:2–3). At Babel, people tried to make a name for themselves and ended scattered. To Abram, God promises to "make your name great," and promises to bless the scattered families of the earth through him. That is next week.

Sin Spreads, Judgment Falls, Grace Holds On (Genesis 3–11)

STORY	SIN	JUDGMENT	GRACE
The Fall *Gen 3*	Took the fruit	Death; driven from Eden	The promise (3:15); garments of skins
Cain *Gen 4*	Killed his brother	Cursed from the ground; a wanderer	A mark to protect him (4:15)
The Flood *Gen 6–9*	Violence filled the earth	The flood	Noah found favor; the ark; the rainbow
Babel *Gen 11*	"Let us make a name"	Languages confused; scattered	The call of Abram (12:1–3)

The sin grows from one act to a whole world. But every judgment carries a mercy, and the line of promise never breaks.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE East of Eden, two men still "walked with God": Enoch (5:24) and Noah (6:9). Fellowship with God was still possible outside the garden, by faith. At Babel, people tried to build their way up to heaven, and God "came down" (11:5). That is the pattern of the whole Bible. We cannot climb up to God. He comes down to us, and one day the Word will become flesh and dwell among us (John 1:14).

THE LAMB Abel offered "the firstborn of his flock" by faith, and God accepted it (Gen. 4:4; Heb. 11:4). After the flood, Noah offered burnt offerings, and God "smelled the pleasing aroma" (8:21). Paul uses the same picture for the cross: Christ "gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God" (Eph. 5:2).

The Turn: A Better Word Than Abel's

Abel's blood cried out from the ground, and it cried for justice. Every murder since has added its voice. So has every wrong done to you, and every wrong you have done. If the story ended there, the cry of the blood would be the last word.

But listen to how the book of Hebrews describes what Christians have come to: "to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and to the sprinkled blood that speaks a better word than the blood of Abel" (Heb. 12:24). A mediator is a go-between who brings God and people together. Abel's blood says, Guilty. Jesus' blood says, Forgiven. Abel's blood cried out against his brother. Jesus' blood speaks for his brothers and sisters, even for some who had shouted for his death (Acts 2:36–41). Lamech multiplied revenge. Jesus took the full weight of our sin on himself and answered it with mercy past all counting.

And think about the ark. There was one ark, with one door, and God himself shut it. Everyone inside was safe, not because they were better swimmers or better people, but because they were in the ark. Peter connects it to Jesus directly. The eight in the ark "were brought safely through water," and he goes on: "Baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you, not as a removal of dirt from the body but as an appeal to God for a good conscience, through the resurrection of Jesus Christ" (1 Pet. 3:20–21). Baptism is the washing with water "in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" that Jesus gave his church as the sign of belonging to him (Matt. 28:19). Peter is careful. The water itself does not save, "not as a removal of dirt." The risen Christ saves, received by faith, and baptism is God's sign and seal of that rescue. The Westminster Confession puts it plainly: grace and salvation are not so tied to baptism that no one can be saved without it, or that everyone baptized is surely born again (WCF 28.5). If you have trusted Christ and have not been baptized, talk to a pastor about it. Like the ark's one door, Jesus is the only way in. He said, "I am the door. If anyone enters by me, he will be saved" (John 10:9). Judgment is coming again. Not by water, because God promised that (Gen. 9:11), but by fire. Peter says the present world is "stored up for fire, being kept until the day of judgment" (2 Pet. 3:7). There is one place of safety: Christ.

And Babel? On the day of Pentecost, a Jewish harvest feast fifty days after Passover, after Jesus rose and ascended, God poured out his Spirit, and people "from every nation under heaven" heard the apostles "telling in our own tongues the mighty works of God" (Acts 2:5, 11). At Babel, God divided the languages to scatter proud people. At Pentecost, he spoke through the languages to gather humbled ones. And at the end of the story, John sees "a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb" (Rev. 7:9). The scattered families of Babel will be gathered, around Jesus.

So come in. You do not have to build a tower to reach God. You cannot. He has come down. You do not have to keep score of every wrong done to you or carry your own guilt like Cain wandering the earth. Turn from your sin, and trust the Savior whose blood speaks a better word. The door is open, and while it is open, come.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1 **Read the four stories.** Read Genesis 4, then 6–9, then 11:1–9. Notice each time God asks a question or makes a promise.

2 **Name the crouching sin.** What sin is "crouching at the door" of your life right now? Name it to God, and ask for his help to rule over it (Gen. 4:7).

3 **Put down the ledger.** Think of one person you are keeping score against. Pray for them by name this week, and ask God to help you forgive as you have been forgiven.

4 **Be your brother's keeper.** Cain asked, "Am I my brother's keeper?" The answer is yes. Check on one person this week who needs someone to notice them.

5 **Let the rainbow preach.** The next time you see one, thank God that he keeps his promises, and that he is holding the world together for the sake of his rescue plan.

6 **Memorize Genesis 6:8.** “But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.” Grace comes first.

Before Lesson 6: *Read Genesis 12, 15, and 22. Lesson 6 opens Unit 2: the call of Abraham and the covenant promise that carries the rest of the Bible.*

For Discussion

1. Genesis 4–11 shows sin spreading from one act to a whole world. Where do you see small sins grow into bigger ones, in the world or in your own life?
2. God warned Cain that sin was “crouching at the door.” What does it look like to “rule over it” (Gen. 4:7)? What help do Christians have that Cain did not?
3. Lamech multiplied revenge; Jesus multiplied forgiveness (Gen. 4:24; Matt. 18:22). Why is keeping score so natural to us? What would it take for you to stop?
4. “Noah found favor” comes before “Noah was a righteous man.” Why does that order matter?
5. The flood washed the earth but not the human heart (Gen. 8:21). What does that tell us about what we really need?
6. At Babel, people tried to make a name for themselves. Where do you see that same drive today, in culture or in yourself?
7. Hebrews says Jesus’ blood “speaks a better word than the blood of Abel” (Heb. 12:24). What “better word” do you need to hear from him this week?

Sources & For Further Study

- On חֵן and חָנַן: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*; Koehler and Baumgartner, *HALOT*, s.v. On the Noah/ḥen wordplay: Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis 1–15* (Word Biblical Commentary), on 6:8.
- On Genesis 4:24 and Matthew 18:22: the Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) of Genesis 4:24 reads *hebdomēkontakis hepta*, the same phrase as Matthew 18:22. David S. Jones, *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*, chapters 1 and 8.
- On the covenant with Noah: O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Covenants*, chapter “The Covenant with Noah: The Covenant of Preservation.” Westminster Confession of Faith 2.1; 28.5.
- For further reading: Derek Kidner, *Genesis* (Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries); Bruce K. Waltke, *Genesis: A Commentary*.



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